

In 1845, when confronted with the question of the economic viability of the railways in India, the Court of Directors noted in a despatch to the Viceroy of India that as “the people of India are poor ... remuneration for railroads in India must, for the present, be drawn chiefly from the conveyance of merchandise, and not from passengers.” The Court's scepticism, as it turned out, was unfounded. Indians took to rail travel quite enthusiastically despite its unaffordability. As early as 1870, around 18.22 million passengers used trains, a number that shot up to 520 million in 1919–20. Up to 90 per cent of these, noted Indian historian Ritika Prasad in her book *Tracks of Change*, travelled by third class; most were Indians with a marginal number of Eurasians, and some domiciled European military orphans.

A matter of class

While there was no written law against Indians travelling in the first and second class, the numbers were negligible.

It turns out that even those Indians who could afford to travel thus were often coerced or harassed into making other plans by their British or Eurasian co-passengers who were uncomfortable about sharing the space with natives. Indian travellers then were packed in huge numbers into third-class compartments. Within this subsection too, people were steeped in the notions of segregation and discrimination on the basis of caste, class, gender, social rank, or religion among themselves. There were continuous demands by Indians for separate accommodation within third class on the basis of religion or caste hierarchies. So much so that the introduction of females-only compartments met with strong disapproval from the “higher” castes, who considered it beneath their social standing that “their women” would travel with those of lower classes.

Inhumane conditions

A typical third-class carriage on a broad-gauge railway had space for about 120 people. Newspapers from the period, however, report how these carriages were often without seats. The *Rohilkhand Akhbar* dated 14 June 1876, noted that there was no limit to the number of persons